Task-5 Cybercrime Awareness Case Study & Prevention Guide

Part A – Case Study: UPI/Online Payment Fraud

What the crime is:

UPI fraud is a growing cybercrime in India where attackers exploit the convenience of instant digital payments. They manipulate victims into authorizing transactions or sharing sensitive details like UPI PINs, leading to direct financial loss.

How it typically happens (step-by-step):

1. Initial Contact**:** The fraudster poses as a bank representative, online seller, or customer support agent, often reaching out via phone calls, WhatsApp, or SMS.
2. Creating Urgency**:** They claim an urgent issue—such as a refund, cashback, or blocked account—and pressure the victim to act quickly.
3. Fake Requests: The attacker sends a UPI "collect request" or asks the victim to enter their UPI PIN to "receive money."
4. Victim Action**:** Believing the request is genuine, the victim approves the request or shares their PIN.
5. Fraudulent Transaction**:** The attacker immediately withdraws funds from the victim's account.

Who is usually targeted:
Students, first-time digital payment users, and busy professionals are prime targets. Fraudsters exploit lack of awareness and the tendency to trust official-sounding calls.

Consequences:
Victims face instant monetary loss, sometimes draining entire accounts. Beyond finances, attackers may misuse personal data for identity theft. The emotional toll—stress, embarrassment, and reduced trust in digital platforms—can be severe.

Real incident:
In 2022, the Reserve Bank of India reported multiple cases where fraudsters tricked users into entering their UPI PIN during fake refund calls, resulting in thousands of rupees being stolen.